

# Present Perfect vs Past Simple

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet &amp; answer key

## Quick answer

**Both are past tenses, but the choice depends on time. Use:**

- 1 Past simple for a finished time — I saw her yesterday.
- 2 Present perfect for a link to now — I've seen that film.
- 3 Past simple to say when; present perfect when the time is unknown or unimportant.

*If you can say exactly when it happened, use the past simple. Finished-time words (yesterday, in 2019, last week) force the past simple.*

## At a glance

|              | Past Simple                        | Present Perfect                             |
|--------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Time         | finished and specific              | unfinished or unspecified                   |
| Signal words | yesterday, ago, in 2019, last week | ever, never, just, already, yet, since, for |
| Focus        | when it happened                   | the result or experience <b>now</b>         |
| Example      | I <b>lost</b> my keys yesterday.   | <b>I've lost</b> my keys — I can't get in.  |

## Learning objectives

- Can select the past simple or present perfect according to time reference and signal words (CEFR B1).
- Can correct the typical L1 error of using the present perfect with finished-time expressions.
- Can transform between the two tenses while keeping the same meaning.



# Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Present Perfect vs Past Simple · CEFR B1

Name: \_\_\_\_\_

Date: \_\_\_\_\_

1. I \_\_\_\_ my keys, so I can't open the door.

A. lost

B. have lost

C. was losing

D. lose

2. We \_\_\_\_ to Paris last summer.

A. have gone

B. went

C. have been

D. go

3. \_\_\_\_ you ever \_\_\_\_ a famous person?

A. Did / meet

B. Have / met

C. Have / meet

D. Did / met

4. She \_\_\_\_ at this school since 2018.

A. worked

B. has worked

C. works

D. was working

5. When \_\_\_\_ you \_\_\_\_ the news?

A. did / hear

B. have / heard

C. did / heard

D. have / hear

6. He \_\_\_\_ his leg last week, so he can't play now.

A. broke

B. has broken

C. breaks

D. was breaking

7. I \_\_\_\_ that film three times. It's my favourite.

A. saw

B. have seen

C. see

D. had seen

8. I've known her \_\_\_\_ ten years.

A. since

B. for

C. from

D. during

9. Rewrite with the same meaning: 'This is my first visit to Rome.'

A. I went to Rome once before.

B. I have never been to Rome before.

C. I have been to Rome many times.

D. I didn't go to Rome.

10. \_\_\_\_ you \_\_\_\_ your keys? We can't leave without them.

A. Did / lose

B. Have / lost

C. Have / lose

D. Did / lost

# Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **B. have lost** — A recent action with a present result takes the present perfect: 'have lost'.
2. **B. went** — A finished-time expression like 'last summer' always takes the past simple: 'went'.
3. **B. Have / met** — Experience questions use 'Have + subject + ever + past participle': 'Have you ever met...?'.
4. **B. has worked** — A situation that started in the past and continues takes the present perfect with 'since': 'has worked'.
5. **A. did / hear** — 'When' asks for a specific time, so it takes the past simple: 'When did you hear...?'.
6. **A. broke** — Even though there's a result now, 'last week' is a finished time, which forces the past simple: 'broke'.
7. **B. have seen** — Experiences counted up to now ('three times') take the present perfect: 'have seen'.
8. **B. for** — 'For' + a period of time (ten years). 'Since' would need a starting point.
9. **B. I have never been to Rome before.** — A first visit means no previous experience: 'I have never been to Rome before.'
10. **B. Have / lost** — An action with a present result and no stated time takes the present perfect: 'Have you lost...?'.